

gangs of Punjab, UP's mafiosi or Tamil Nadu poachers, there seems to exist a parallel bazaar where sophisticated firearms are sloshing around. The striking fact about the May 29 murder of Punjab singer Sidhu Moosewala was the gun: a Russia-make AN-94 assault rifle, rare even in Russia and used only by its elite forces. But that's an extreme case. Pilferage from domestic sources is more common: the Maoists, for one, were found to be procuring their booty from paramilitary armouries. A May 11 NIA chargesheet had already traced the supply lines to an officer, Kartik Behera, skimming off the BSF. And where you can't get the real thing, there's always the trusted Indian DIY version.

THE ILLEGAL FACTORIES

On July 10, when an illegal firearms factory was busted and semi-finished arms seized in Uttar Pradesh's Mainpuri district, the police discovered Bihar-based gang members operating from there. Earlier, in April, a similar illegal gun factory was busted in Jharkhand's Dumka district. Those arrested once again revealed their links to Bihar. In November 2021, a much bigger illegal arms manufacturing unit was busted in Jharkhand's Hazaribagh district. Apart from the famous Munger gunsmiths in Bihar, a community around Khargone in MP is also well known for manufacturing high-quality illegal guns. The police busted six illegal arms factories in Khargone in April after violence during Ramnavami celebrations.

The statistics bring out a disturbing trend. Some 74,581 firearms were seized in 2020—almost 99 per cent (73,169) unlicensed, according to the National Crimes Records Bureau. In fact, the number of illegal firearms cases went up from 38,855 in 2018 to 44,394 in 2020. The states that lag behind in all other indices top the charts here: UP alone accounted for over half the cases (26,305), followed by MP (3,246), Bihar (3,166) and Rajasthan (2,458). Some 162 illegal gun factories have been exposed in the past five years. With raids and increased surveillance, many gun-making units from Munger have shifted to Jharkhand (which explains the busts there, says a senior police officer)—besides West Bengal and UP. Clearly, demand is universally on the rise.

IN BIHAR, DEPENDING ON YOUR CONTACTS, A DESI SPINOFF OF AN AK-47 CAN BE PROCURED FOR ANYTHING FROM ₹1-3 LAKH

The growth in this grey market is not just about numbers: it comes with a concomitant internal variegation, an expansion in the range of goods available. The cost of illegal firearms depends on the model and quality. A country-made pistol (*katta*) is the cheapest at Rs 5,000-7,000 while a knockoff of an AK-47 or a carbine can cost a few lakhs. Over the years, the booming demand has resulted in manufacturers improving on the rusty designs peddled earlier. Police officers in Patna say the '*desi katta*' is no longer a valid term. Earlier, the *katta*, a single-shot weapon with a basic barrel and a trigger mechanism, was famously temperamental—becoming unsalvageable after a few rounds of firing. But now, gunsmiths use sophisticated machines in illegal factories to create much better firearms. Automatics with magazines are the 'high-demand' weapons.

As for ammunition, at least a part of it is blamed on rogue elements at central ordnance factories, who smuggle out large consignments regularly. In 2021, after another bust, Purshottam Lal Rajak, an ex-armourer of the Central Ordnance Depot (COD), Jabalpur, MP, was identified as the kingpin of a gun-running racket. Some 22 AK-47s were recovered from him. How many had already made their way, via arms smugglers, to Maoists and garden-variety criminals? Your guess would be as good as that of the police. Clearly, we've only seen the tip of the barrel. ■